

Glass half full?

Google's Glass has been making a few waves recently. There are already "Google Explorers" walking about US cities wearing them, and even apps are starting to appear... Of course, as usual with any new tech, there are fans and critics – those who cannot wait to get their hands on a pair, and those who scream bloody murder at the privacy implications.

The major concern seems to be Glass' ability to take videos and pictures on command. The concern is that what the wearer sees, can now be recorded. Of course, that's the case right now as well, spy glasses with hidden cameras are not really a new concept. Just a quick Google for it will throw up options ranging from the \$50 to \$300 price range (hardly unaffordable) which is much cheaper than the \$1,500 for Google Glass.

What I'm trying to say is, perverts will find a way, regardless of what Google does or doesn't do. In fact, anything Google brings out will get enough publicity to make sure anyone with net access will know exactly what the product looks like. It'll be no different than someone pointing a camera phone at you, though they'll also have to say, "OK Glass. Record a video", hardly spy novel stuff.

What bothers me more about Glass is the voice interface. Let's face it, voice activated UIs are seriously not a new concept. Then again, neither was touch or multi-touch until Apple perfected it. However, touch is still ideal for personal devices. In the crowded cities and towns where most of the world's tech-enabled population lives, personal space is important. We're already irritated by people who talk in loud voices to others (on phones or in person), can you imagine how irritating it would be with everyone talking to their gadgets as well? Besides, even Google's Executive Chairman, Eric Schmidt, has been quoted as saying that the voice control is "the weirdest thing".

I have serious doubts about voice ever becoming popular for systems or gadgets that aren't located in our homes or other controlled, noise-free environments. It's just not feasible, and is, well, just plain rude too!

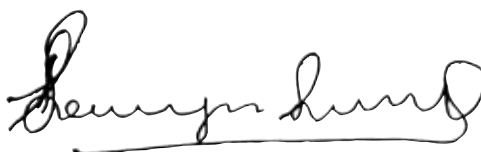
Augmented reality, however, certainly is the future. Even if it's not something you wear, or something as distracting as glasses, it certainly is the way forward. Just think of a simple appli-

cation, on a bus for example. Why can't the windows of a bus be augmented to display what's passing by, where the latest sales are, what area you're in, and perhaps even remind the person in the nearest seat that their stop is next?

Perhaps even in private transport, the windscreen of our cars can have subtle areas out of driving vision that give us directions or information such as what roads are one way. Beats looking down and away from the road to look at your GPS device anyway. Incidentally, many believe that voice is best suited for controlled environments like your car, though I am personally against anything that distracts a driver of a car – especially on India's crowded and crazy streets.

I certainly don't believe that touch is the finest solution to the human computer interface that we can come up with, but it certainly isn't going away anytime soon. However, enhancing reality (augmenting it), or even creating false realities (movies?) is the future of technology that we all want. 3D is already boring; we want 4D, with sensations, smells – not just touch but "feel" as well.

This is why I think Google Glass (or Durex's Fundawear, even) is just a step in the direction the world wants to go. None of it is as finished a product as the multi-touch based UI from Apple was, but then again, it's a much harder barrier to cross. Eventually, I'm sure we'll all be as used to seeing information pop up around us randomly as we are with pop-up ads on web sites today. Perhaps we'll be as immune to it all as we are today – as commonplace as someone tapping away like mad at a screen, probably playing a game or texting... I can't help but smile when I see that though, because it always reminds me of the birdbrained sparrows I'd have to chase out of my house for doing the same thing to the bathroom mirror! 



PS: Don't forget next month is our 12th anniversary special, and we're already working on making it memorable. We don't think you'll ever look at 12 of your keyboard keys the same again, for example...



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